

Overcoming Barriers to Preserving and Sharing Qualitative Data

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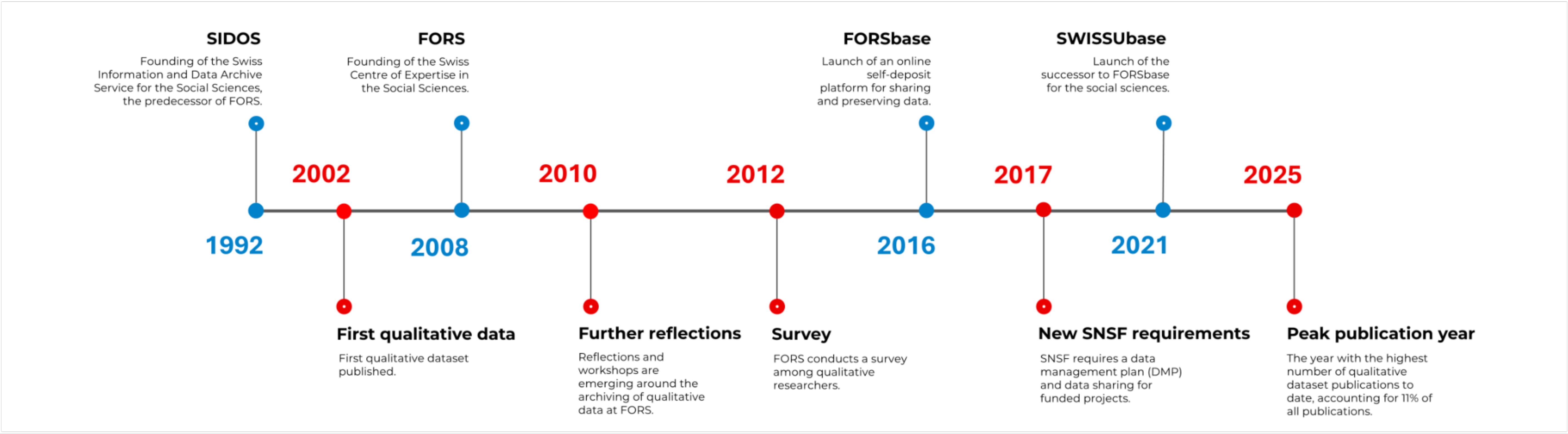
Archiving and sharing qualitative social science data remain uncommon, partly due to ethical and data protection challenges. However, our experience at FORS shows that there are ways to address these challenges.

FORS – Swiss Centre of Expertise in the Social Sciences

- FORS is a national research infrastructure supporting the social science research community in Switzerland.
- Primarily funded by the Swiss National Science Foundation (SNSF) and hosted by the University of Lausanne, FORS operates Switzerland's main social science data archive.
- FORS ensures the long-term preservation and dissemination of research data and provides data management consulting and training.

Integration of Qualitative Data at FORS

- 2010: FORS, traditionally focused on quantitative data, began reflecting on qualitative data archiving.
- 2012: A survey of qualitative researchers identified key barriers to data sharing: ethical and legal constraints, publishing priorities, loss of control, and limited resources.
- Since then: FORS has developed curation expertise, adopted best practices, adapted policies and guidance, and enhanced its platform to support qualitative data.

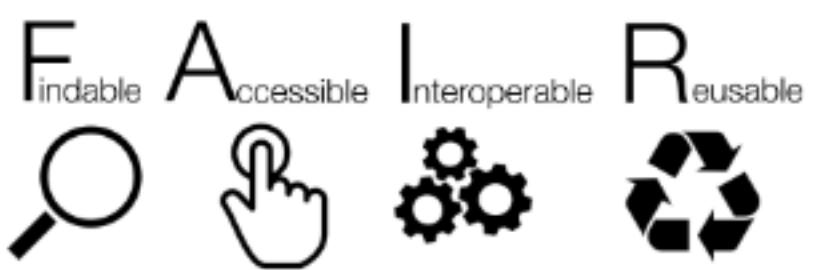


SWISSUbase: Secure Swiss Platform

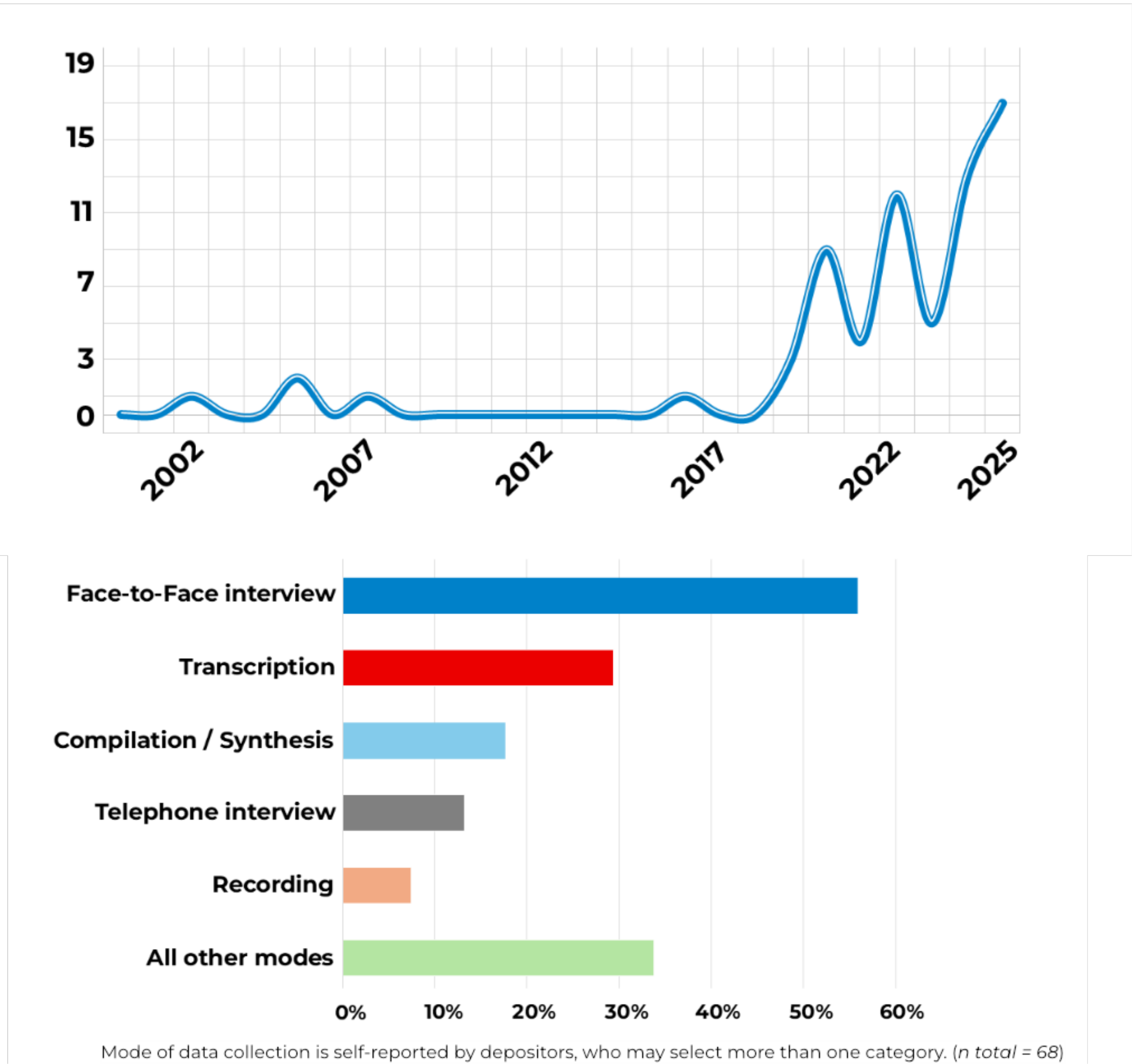
- SWISSUbase is a national, FAIR-compliant platform for sharing and long-term preservation of research data on secure Swiss servers. SWISSUbase for the social sciences, operated by FORS, is CoreTrustSeal certified, demonstrating compliance with international standards for data curation and preservation.
- Controlled access protects sensitive qualitative data: users must register, describe the intended use, and accept a usage licence. Additional restrictions, such as specific usage purposes, author approval, or embargoes, can be applied.

Personal Support and Expert Curation

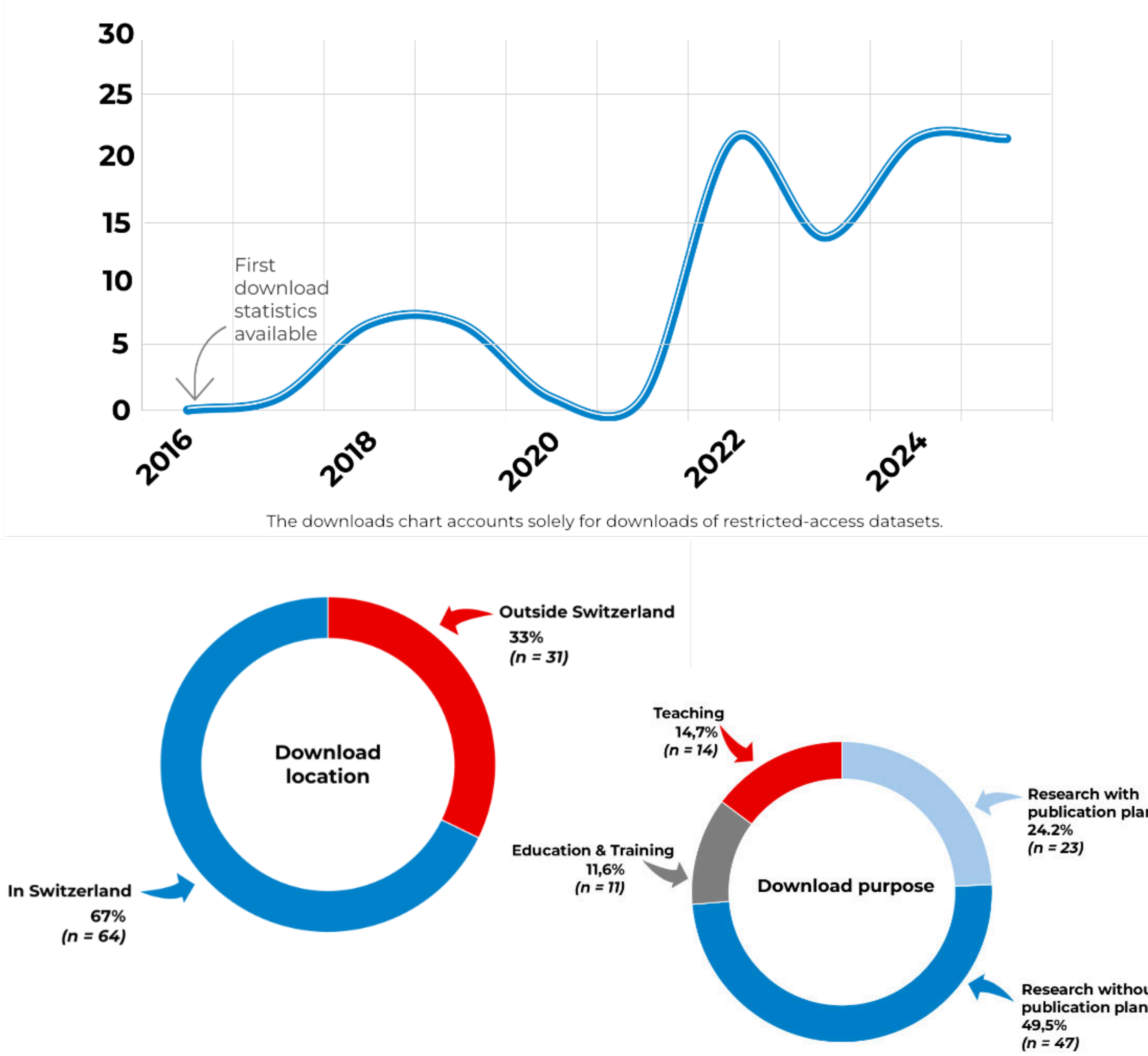
- FORS provides data management support throughout the full research data life-cycle.
- Qualitative-data-specific resources and training include guidance on informed consent and data anonymisation, as well as an interview transcript template.
- Individual deposit support and expert curation include quality checks for anonymisation, file formats, metadata consistency, and documentation completeness.



Dataset Publications



Dataset Downloads



Challenges and Next Steps

- Refine policies and procedures, including access when depositor approval is required but no longer obtainable.
- Expand preservation and sharing beyond textual data to formats such as audio and video.
- Explore secure access solutions for sensitive data, including remote desktop and on-site access.

Contact and Further Information



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